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Wireworms

Limonius spp. and others

Updated: 08/2008



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Description of the Pest

[Wireworms](#) are the soil-dwelling larvae of [click beetles](#). They resemble mealworms and are slender, elongate, yellowish to brown with smooth, tough skin. The body is usually cylindrical, but flat on the lower side. There are six short legs close together near the head, and the tip of the abdomen bears a flattened plate with a pair of [short hooks](#).

Wireworms may remain in the soil as larvae from 1 to 3 or more years, depending upon the species and the food supply.

Damage

Wireworms feed on seeds and root portions of a wide variety of plants. In corn they can destroy germinating seeds and tiny seedlings. Often the wireworm will be found near the damaged or missing seed or plant. Wireworms will also attack young plants, resulting in weakened plants or a reduced stand. Damage is most likely to occur where corn is planted into a field formerly in pasture or weedy alfalfa.

Management

If wireworms have been a serious problem in the past, a preventive seed treatment or a treatment at planting may be necessary.

Pesticides and Natural Enemy Releases

Not all registered pesticides are listed. **The following are ranked by their IPM value, with the most effective and least harmful to natural enemies, honey bees, and the [environment](#) listed at the top of the table.** When choosing a pesticide, consider information related to water and [air quality](#), resistance management, and the pesticide's properties and application timing. Use [PestManage](#) to compare summarized management options for different pests in the same crop. Always carefully read the label of the product being used and take all necessary [precautions when handling pesticides](#).



 [Expand table](#)

Rank 	Active ingredient 	Example trade name
Application Timing Varies (See <i>UC IPM Pest Management Guidelines</i>)		
A	thiamethoxam (seed treatment)	Cruiser 5FS
B	clothianidin (seed treatment)	Poncho 600

For more information, see the [Wireworms](#) page.

— No information.

I Do not apply or allow to drift to plants that are flowering including weeds. Do not allow pesticide to contaminate water accessible to bees including puddles.

II Do not apply or allow to drift to plants that are flowering including weeds, except when the application is made between sunset and midnight if allowed by the pesticide label and regulations. Do not allow pesticide to contaminate water accessible to bees including puddles.

III No bee precaution, except when required by the pesticide label or regulations.

- ‡ [a b](#) Restricted entry interval (REI) is the number of hours (unless otherwise noted) from treatment until the treated area can be safely entered without personal protective equipment. Preharvest interval (PHI) is the number of days from treatment to harvest. In some cases, the REI exceeds the PHI. The longer of the two intervals is the minimum time that must elapse before harvest.
- ¹ [↩](#) Group numbers for insecticides and miticides are assigned by the [Insecticide Resistance Action Committee](#) (IRAC). Insecticides with unknown modes of action are assigned mode-of-action group

numbers (MoAs) that begin with UN. Rotate pesticides with a different mode-of-action group number, and do not use products with the same mode-of-action group number more than twice per season to help prevent the development of resistance. For example, the organophosphates have a group number of 1B; insecticides with a 1B group number should be alternated with insecticides that have a group number other than 1B.

- ² [↩](#) Range of insect and mite groups affected by a pesticide. **Broad** means the pesticide affects most groups of insects and mites; **narrow** means the pesticide affects only a few specific groups.
- ³ [↩](#) Risk of harm to honey bees. For more information, see [Bee Precaution Pesticide Ratings](#).
- ⁴ [↩](#) Risk of harm to predatory mites. Toxicities are generally to western predatory mite, *Galendromus occidentalis*. Where differences have been measured in toxicity of the pesticide-resistant strain versus the native strain, these are listed as pesticide-resistant strain or native strain.
- ⁵ [a b](#) Risk of harm to parasitoids and general predators. Toxicities are averages of reported effects and should be used only as a general guide. Actual toxicity of a specific insecticide depends on factors including the application rate, environmental conditions, and the life stage and species of a parasitoid or predator.
- ⁶ [↩](#) Length of time residue affects natural enemies. **Short** means hours to days; **moderate** means days to 2 weeks; and **long** means many weeks or months.
- ⁷ [↩](#) Risk of harm to fish from leaching, based on USDA Natural Resources Conservation Service Windows Pesticide Screening Tool (WIN-PST).
- ⁸ [↩](#) Risk of harm to fish from adsorbed runoff, based on USDA Natural Resources Conservation Service Windows Pesticide Screening Tool (WIN-PST).

- ⁹ [↩](#) Risk of harm to fish from solution runoff, based on USDA Natural Resources Conservation Service Windows Pesticide Screening Tool (WIN-PST).
- ¹⁰ [↩](#) Risk of harm to humans from leaching, based on USDA Natural Resources Conservation Service Windows Pesticide Screening Tool (WIN-PST).
- ¹¹ [↩](#) Risk of harm to humans from solution runoff, based on USDA Natural Resources Conservation Service Windows Pesticide Screening Tool (WIN-PST).
- ¹² [↩](#) Date information was last updated in the *UC IPM Pest Management Guidelines*.



UC IPM Pest Management Guidelines: Corn

UC ANR Publication 3443

L.D. Godfrey, Entomology, UC Davis

[S.D. Wright](#) (emeritus), UC Cooperative Extension Tulare and Kings counties

[C.G. Summers](#) (emeritus), Entomology, UC Davis and Kearney Agricultural Research and Extension Center, Parlier

C.A. Frate (emeritus), UC Cooperative Extension Tulare County
Acknowledgement for Contributions to Invertebrates

[M.J. Jimenez](#) (emeritus), UC Cooperative Extension Tulare County

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